Task 'Collaborative Discussion Summary Code of Ethics and Professional Conduct' Unit 1

Collaborative Discussion: Codes of Ethics and Professional Conduct

'Initial Post'

The ACM case study Automated Active Response Weaponry examines the ethical challenges that computing professionals working for a defense contractor faced while developing autonomous surveillance and response systems. As the company considered expanding its technology to include lethal capabilities, several engineers became concerned about the possible misuse of such capabilities and decided to leave the organization. Their intention to disclose their concerns creates a conflict between professional responsibility, public safety and contractual confidentiality.

(ACM, 2018.).

The ACM Code of Ethics provides a useful framework for assessing such conflicting situations. Principle 1.1 prioritizes human well-being, while Principle 1.2 requires computing professionals to avoid harm.

(ACM, 2018).

These principles suggest that engineers should carefully assess the consequences of autonomous weaponry, including risks to civilians, privacy and human rights. Although technology may offer security benefits, insufficient safeguards could result in serious harm. Professionals should therefore consider not only whether a system works as intended but also how and under which cases it could be misused.

Legal issues also arise because the engineers may face consequences for disclosing confidential information. Whether such disclosure is legally protected depends on the relevant jurisdiction, contractual terms and applicable whistleblowing legislation. International humanitarian law may also become relevant if autonomous weapons are used in armed conflict.

(Davison, 2018).

However, legal compliance alone does not guarantee ethical conduct.

Automated weapons raise social and ethical concerns about accountability, discrimination and the loss of meaningful human control over decisions involving force. Public trust in computing professionals may decline if commercial interests are prioritized over human safety.

The British Computer Society (BCS) Code of Conduct similarly emphasizes the public interest, professional competence and integrity, duty to relevant authority, and duty to the profession.

Both codes expect professionals to consider the wider consequences of their work. However, the BCS framework explicitly addresses responsibilities to employers alongside public-interest obligations, highlighting the difficulty of balancing confidentiality with ethical concerns.

(BCS, 2019).

In my opinion, engineers demonstrate ethical integrity by treating potential harm seriously. However, raising concerns through appropriate reporting channels and seeking legal advice may have helped protect the public while reducing

disproportionate disclosure. Ultimately, responsible computing requires technical expertise, independent judgement and accountability for the social consequences of innovation.

References

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